

Crytstals made Crytstal Clear

Infographic by Justin Diep

Blue Lace Agate

This crystal is associated with stress relief. It can calm overactive minds and nerves because of its sky blue color. Its properties can heal by opening energy channels to unconditional love.

Aventurine

This stone is known to bring luck and prosperity. Aventurine can also bring wealth and success. It can guide people to be open-minded and open-hearted to attract more opportunities.

Clear Quartz

This crystal is known for its high vibrations. It can clear ones mind and body. It is often used to help oneself manifestations because of its clearing properties. Some say clear quartz can amplify the affects of other crystals.

Black Tourmaline

Also known as the bodyguard crystal, black tourmaline can block off negative energies. The stone can absorb negative energies from the environment. Black tourmaline can also add a sense of security.

Fluorite

The green and purple color of this crystal gives it an energy that heals and rejuvenates the aura around it. The green purifies the heart chakra by aligning the mind with the heart. The purple stimulates the third eye chakra allowing people to find the way for spiritual expansion and inner peace and allow for deeper focus on things such as studies.

Amethyst

The purple color allows a strong connection to the third eye. Its healing properties can bring peace, relaxation and spiritual awareness which makes it one of the most sought after crystals in the world.

Carnelian

The warm, vibrant stone can boost self confidence and the power of true expression giving it the name of the artists stone. It is associated with self-confidence and taking bold action.

Jade

This stone is highly sought out for its luck and wisdom. The shade of green makes this crystal stand for growth, wealth and longevity. Its youth and anti-ageing properties can also be attributed to its special shade of green.

Local crystal shop owner gives insight on benefits of crystals

Lia Becker
Reporter

Stones and crystals have grown in popularity this last year for their collectability and transcendent properties.

Crystals are believed to be able to change the flow of energy in one's body to heal the mind, body and soul. There are many different kinds of crystals that have an array of different healing abilities.

From stones that relieve stress and anxiety of assignments and the fear of ACT results that impacts juniors' lives, or stones that restore energy, giving students the motivation to finally do their schoolwork, or tiny rocks to shake in one's hand to grant them

the tiniest crumb of serotonin, there is something for just about everybody.

"Even if someone just buys something because they think it's pretty and brings them joy, to me that's a benefit," owner of Hearthiside Candles & Curios, Alex Fernandez said. "The only downside I can think of is running out of room to store them all."

Before buying crystals for any reason, the best thing to do is to research about the pros and cons of every crystal, and the history and ideas tied to them. Many who follow along with crystals are versed in chakras, various points of the body explained as nodes of psychic energy, seen in Hinduism, Buddhism and many

other cultures.

"I have seen people using stones and actually changing their lives and achieving their goals," Fernandez said.

Another set of topics to research is what and where is being bought. Just like any other products, there are bound to be fakes. Some places sell dyed and shaped resin under the guise of crystals.

"Working with the stones, people should do their research and that includes traditional information, reading lots of books, trusting their own intuition and being very careful of what is talked about online because there isn't always good information in places that aren't regulated," Fernandez said.

It's best to purchase stones in person rather than online if one is worried about fakes. Two places to purchase stones and crystals is Custom Gems at 8487 Frederick St in Omaha and Hearthiside Candles and Curios at 6619 S 77th Street in Ralston.

"Our stones have a very wide range of prices, starting at 99 cents, so we try and make things affordable to everybody at every income level," Fernandez said.

When choosing crystals, there are many ways to pick. One way is intuition, which can be cultivated through meditation, an activity recommended by Trust Admin of Premier Trust Lu Hug, who managed a metaphysical shop for twelve years. Meditation is not only sitting cross legged

and close eyed but also takes form of singing and dancing and many other activities.

"Learning to listen to and trust your vibrations is a powerful tool that will help with literally everything else," Hug said.

For those aiming to focus, fluorite is notable for having earned the name 'the student's stone.' For those aiming to have some motivation and energy, carnelians are popular. For all that the community is going through in these trying times, black tourmaline, aventurine and amethysts are advised.

"Remember that everything you read is a broad generalization of the observation of others," Hug said, "Let it inform but not control your experiences."

Subantarctic temperatures relieve pain

Justin Diep
Copy Editor

Freezing someone's pain away is something humans have been doing for centuries. Some athletes may jump into an ice bath to jump start their recovery after their workout, while others may partake in a form of freezing therapy called cryotherapy.

Cryotherapy uses freezing temperatures to treat pain for everyone, not just athletes. It has been around since the 1980's. It is more popularly taken as whole-body cryotherapy.

"It's a type of cold therapy that used nitrogen gas to cool the surface of the skin, which results in changes within the body that helps fight pain and inflammation from the inside out," general manager of West Omaha Cryotherapy Brianna Huddle said.

Patients are required to wear protective clothing like socks, gloves and undergarments before entering the sauna to prevent the possibility of frostbite. Temperatures range from -225°F to -260°F. Sessions can last two to five minutes, depending on the spa.

"The risks involved with cryotherapy are generally related to specific health contraindications, (reasons not to take medical treatment) to the physiological responses cryotherapy induces," Matthew Carney, President and CEO of West Omaha Cryotherapy said. "We have a detailed list of these contraindications that each client is required to review prior to their first session."

Advocates of cryotherapy often cite benefits such as pain relief, muscle recovery, weight loss, improved mood and reduced anxiety.

"The result is a system-wide response by the body where its natural cold defenses are activated," Carney said. "The systemic reactions that take place when the body engages its 'survival mode' are how each benefit is achieved."

Many West Omaha Cryotherapy patients reported relief of pain and inflammation. Some even reported gaining increased mobility in their limbs. Mary Z. took daily cryotherapy sessions in preparation for knee surgery.

"Cryo has diminished inflammation and swelling so successfully that I am not taking any pain medication or anti-inflammatory medications," Mary said. "I will continue daily therapy after my surgery."

It is important to note that the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) hasn't approved any whole-body cryotherapy devices, nor has it verified the claimed health benefits. They also recommend consulting with a doctor before booking a session.

"Given a growing interest from consumers in whole body cryotherapy, the FDA has informally reviewed the medical literature available on this subject," Aron Yustein, medical officer in the FDA's Center for Devices and Radiological Health said.

"We found very little evidence about its safety or effectiveness in treating the conditions for which it is being promoted."



A patient putting on gloves before entering the cryotherapy chamber at West Omaha Cryotherapy is overseen by a trained professional. Liquid nitrogen allows the chamber to be as cold as -260°F to treat pain. "Safe, non-toxic nitrogen vapor flows into the chamber reducing the temperature below -225°F," President and CEO of West Omaha Cryotherapy Matt Carney said. The dry nature of the vapor and the absence of moisture and wind results in a cold, but tolerable treatment."

Cupping therapy offers stress, pain relief

Victoria Besta
Reporter

Balancing and relaxing the body tends to be difficult with stress of everyday activities and fitness. Using some nonstandard practices can help deal with the daily stresses of life. One of these is cupping therapy.

Cupping therapy is done with cups made up of bamboo, clay, silicone or glass. The cups are placed on the skin, usually on the legs or back. They are then left on the skin for three minutes per cup. The cup creates a vacuum suction on the skin that opens up the blood vessels to draw blood to those areas.

Rehab Guru Physical Therapy Clinic Omaha offers numerous treatments including cupping. Diana Schwahn has been a physical therapist and certified athletic trainer for over 25 years.

"There is multiple articles and research about the science

behind cupping therapy and the benefits" Schwahn said.

Some of the health benefits of cupping include helping with pain relief, treating acne that is caused by stress, muscle tension relief and collectively repairing tissue within the body.

"I recommend patients with muscle issues to consider cupping because chemical healing is a great way to recover," Schwahn said.

Cupping has shown to be relaxing, removes toxins and has rapid results. Results can be affected by a person's appetite or skin type. It is recommended to eat lightly or not at all before a cupping session.

Some patients have reported they have been burned or injured after taking cupping. Cupping has not been approved by the Food and Drug Administration. It's recommended to consult with a doctor before taking cupping if there are any concerns.



A patient receives fire cupping therapy. Glass cups are heated with fire to create a vacuum on the skin to make a suction generally used on the back. Other forms of cupping can include wet cupping, cupping with a pump and the use of cups made of many different materials.

COMMUNITY



Photo by | Justin Diep

Mercy Thai located at 96th and L St was recently bought by seven former refugees from Bhutan. The proceeds are going towards a missionary fund to assist in refugee camps in Nepal for Bhutanese refugees. It continues to serve Thai food but in the near future may add Nepalese food.

Former refugees work together, buy restaurant to help other refugees

Justin Diep
Copy Editor

To help displaced families in Nepal seven Bhutanese-Nepali, former refugees came together to buy Mercy Thai Restaurant to send the proceeds back to Nepal.

Bhutan and Nepal are countries in South Asia between India and China. The growing ethnic Nepalese population who lived in Bhutan were subject to ethnic cleansing ordered by the Bhutanese elites starting in the 1980's, according to the Human Rights Watch. More than 100,000 ethnic Nepali people living in Bhutan were forced to flee and move into refugee camps in Nepal, including the new owners of Mercy Thai Restaurant on 96th and L. The owners are just a few of the roughly 1,500-3,000 refugees who have resettled in Omaha according to the Omaha Refugee Task Force.

"Even though they're ethnically Nepalese, they don't have Nepali citizenship or statehood," Senior Manager of Community Initiatives at Refugee Empowerment Center Alana Schriver said. "So, they were forced into these refugee camp situations which are essentially living prisons."

The new owners understand the struggles of living in refugee camps. One of the owners Bijoi Tamanz spent 20 years living in one.

"It's kind of hard over there," Tamanz said. "We don't have good opportunities over there. We have education but not really."

The group wanted to find a business which they could spend their free time on so they could raise money for these Bhutanese-Nepali families still living in those refugee camps. Originally, they were planning on opening a Nepali Indian style restaurant, but when the

opportunity to buy Mercy Thai opened up they went for it.

"We met with one of our Burmese friends, the previous owner, and we talked to them," one of the owners, Bijoi Tamanz, said. "He was trying to sell this restaurant and we bought it."

All the owners have other jobs that allow them to send the profits from the restaurant to a missionary fund run by the New-Life Nepali Church, which sends the money to Nepal.

The church was not available for comment.

As of now, the owners of Mercy Thai are planning on keeping the same menu with Thai classics such as pad Thai but in the near future, they hope to add Nepali food.

Mercy Thai Restaurant is open for dine-in, takeout and delivery on Monday-Saturday from 11 a.m.-2:30 a.m. and from 5-9 p.m. They are closed Sunday.

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